

INTERNATIONAL TEACHING CENTRE

Impact of Growth on Administration Processes a document prepared by the International Teaching Centre July 2005 The dramatic progress achieved on all continents in the course of the Five Year Plan has been reflected in many aspects of the life of the Bahá'í community. The training institute process has continued to enhance the capacity of an increasing number of believers to promote the processes of expansion and consolidation. The enhanced sense of ownership and enthusiasm thus generated, reflected in a marked increase in individual initiative, has been especially evident in advanced clusters where the renewed teaching fervor of the friends is directed towards intensive programs of growth.

One of the welcome results of this new vibrancy is that there is a growing contingent of believers involved in the work of the Cause, serving in numerous capacities within the framework of the Plan. Meanwhile an expanding community of interest is challenging the Bahá'í community to re-conceptualize its boundaries and cater to the requirements of an ever-swelling body of individuals walking together the path towards Bahá'u'lláh. The progress made has been reinforced by the emergence of a new culture of growth in the community.

As these developments have continued at an accelerating pace, several national communities have taken steps to reframe their administrative arrangements, so as to align them with the new requirements. Below is a review of some of the most salient aspects of the developments which impinge on the administration of the processes of growth. This review reflects the experiences of communities in the advance guard of these processes. Whereas in some instances the changes have been relatively minor and adjustments easily made, in other cases they have necessitated a major rethinking of structures and practices.

Administering the Process of Growth at the Cluster Level With the division of countries into small geographic areas, the cluster construct has created a new arena within which the teaching work can be organized on a manageable scale. Large-scale expansion in the past had proven difficult to sustain. Whilst this was principally owing to lack of a systematic process for raising human resources, there was also limited experience with managing the process of growth at the grassroots. In this context, the learning that has been achieved about the administration of growth at the cluster level constitutes one of the major accomplishments in the current Plan.

[signed: International Teaching Centre]